
Northfield & Cole Consulting Group

Employee Handbook

Policies, Procedures & Guidelines for All Team Members

Effective Date: January 1, 2026

Version 3.2

This handbook is the confidential property of Northfield & Cole Consulting Group. It is provided for informational purposes to employees and does not constitute an employment contract.

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1. Welcome & Introduction

On behalf of everyone at Northfield & Cole Consulting Group, welcome. We are glad you have joined our team and we look forward to your contributions. This handbook is designed to help you understand our policies, procedures, and the standards we hold ourselves to as an organization.

This handbook applies to all employees, regardless of position, and supersedes any prior handbooks, memos, or verbal statements regarding the policies described herein. It is not an employment contract and does not alter the at-will nature of employment described in Section 3.

1.1 How to Use This Handbook

Please read this handbook carefully and refer to it whenever you have questions about company policy. If any provision is unclear, contact Human Resources (HR) before acting. The company reserves the right to interpret, modify, suspend, or eliminate any policy in this handbook, with or without notice, at its sole discretion.

1.2 Equal Employment Opportunity

Northfield & Cole Consulting Group is an equal opportunity employer. We are committed to providing equal employment opportunities to all employees and applicants without regard to race, color, religion, sex, national origin, age, disability, genetic information, veteran status, sexual orientation, gender identity, or any other characteristic protected by applicable law. This policy applies to all aspects of employment, including hiring, promotion, compensation, benefits, and termination.

2. About the Company

Northfield & Cole Consulting Group was founded to help organizations solve complex operational and strategic challenges through data-driven consulting. Our team works across industries including finance, healthcare, logistics, and technology.

2.1 Mission Statement

To deliver measurable, lasting value to our clients while fostering an inclusive, collaborative, and growth-oriented environment for our employees.

2.2 Core Values

- **Integrity** – We act honestly and hold ourselves accountable.
- **Excellence** – We pursue the highest quality in everything we deliver.
- **Collaboration** – We work as one team across departments and geographies.
- **Curiosity** – We continuously learn and adapt.
- **Respect** – We treat colleagues and clients with dignity and fairness.

2.3 Organizational Structure

The company operates through five practice groups—Strategy, Operations, Technology, Human Capital, and Analytics—each led by a Practice Director who reports to the Chief Operating Officer. Org charts are maintained on the internal HR portal.

3. Employment Policies

3.1 At-Will Employment

Employment with the company is at-will. This means either the employee or the company may terminate the employment relationship at any time, with or without cause or notice. No manager or representative of the company, other than the CEO, has authority to alter this arrangement, and any such agreement must be in writing.

3.2 Employment Classifications

Employees are classified according to the categories below, which determine eligibility for overtime pay and certain benefits.

Classification	Description	Overtime Eligible
Full-Time	Regularly scheduled to work 30+ hours per week	Varies by role
Part-Time	Regularly scheduled to work fewer than 30 hours per week	Varies by role
Exempt	Not eligible for overtime under the FLSA (e.g., professional, executive, or administrative roles)	No
Non-Exempt	Eligible for overtime pay for hours worked beyond 40 in a workweek	Yes
Temporary	Hired for a specific project or defined period	Varies by role
Intern	Short-term role, often tied to an academic program	Varies by role

3.3 Introductory Period

New employees serve a 90-day introductory period during which performance and fit are assessed. This period does not change the at-will nature of employment, and benefits eligibility is not affected by introductory status unless otherwise stated in the Benefits section.

3.4 Personnel Records & Data Privacy

The company maintains personnel files containing employment-related documents. Employees may request to review their own file by contacting HR with reasonable advance notice. Personal data is handled in accordance with the company's Data Privacy Policy, available on the HR portal.

4. Standards of Conduct

All employees are expected to conduct themselves professionally and ethically. The following sections outline expectations regarding workplace behavior.

4.1 Anti-Harassment & Anti-Discrimination

The company prohibits harassment or discrimination of any kind, including sexual harassment, based on any protected characteristic. This applies to conduct by employees, managers, clients, vendors, or third parties encountered in the course of business, whether in person, by phone, or through electronic communication.

Employees who experience or witness harassment should report it immediately to their manager, HR, or through the confidential ethics hotline. All reports will be investigated promptly and confidentially, and retaliation against anyone who reports in good faith is strictly prohibited.

4.2 Conflicts of Interest

Employees must avoid situations where personal interests could conflict, or appear to conflict, with the interests of the company or its clients. Employees must disclose potential conflicts, such as outside employment, financial interests in competitors, or close personal relationships with clients or vendors, to their manager or HR.

4.3 Confidentiality

Employees may have access to confidential company or client information. Such information may not be disclosed to unauthorized parties during or after employment, except as required by law. Confidentiality obligations survive termination of employment.

4.4 Anti-Bribery & Gifts

Employees may not offer, give, solicit, or accept bribes or improper gifts in connection with company business. Modest, customary business courtesies (e.g., a working lunch) are generally acceptable, but gifts exceeding \$75 in value must be disclosed to HR.

4.5 Drug & Alcohol-Free Workplace

Employees may not report to work under the influence of alcohol or illegal drugs, nor possess, distribute, or use such substances on company premises or while conducting company business. Moderate alcohol consumption may be permitted at approved company events.

5. Workplace Policies

5.1 Work Hours & Attendance

Standard business hours are Monday through Friday, 9:00 a.m. to 5:30 p.m., with a 30-minute unpaid meal break. Department managers may adjust schedules to accommodate client needs. Employees are expected to arrive on time and notify their manager as early as possible in the event of an unavoidable absence or lateness.

5.2 Remote & Hybrid Work

Eligible employees may work remotely up to three days per week, subject to manager approval and role requirements. Remote employees must remain reachable during core hours (10:00 a.m.–4:00 p.m.) and maintain a secure, distraction-free workspace.

5.3 Dress Code

The company follows a business-casual dress code on standard business days, and professional attire is expected for client meetings. Employees should exercise good judgment; on non-client-facing days, casual attire such as jeans is acceptable provided it remains neat and appropriate.

5.4 Attendance & Punctuality Standards

Category	Definition	Notification Required
Planned Absence	Vacation, appointment, or other scheduled time off	At least 5 business days
Unplanned Absence	Illness or emergency	Before shift start, or within 1 hour
Tardiness	Arrival more than 10 minutes after scheduled start	As soon as possible
No Call / No Show	Absence without any notification	Subject to disciplinary action

5.5 Workplace Violence Prevention

The company maintains a zero-tolerance policy toward threats or acts of violence in the workplace. Any employee who feels threatened should report the situation immediately to management, HR, or security.

5.6 Visitors & Building Security

All visitors must sign in at reception and be escorted by an employee. Employees must wear company identification badges at all times while on-site and should not prop open secured entrances for unauthorized individuals.

6. Compensation & Payroll

6.1 Pay Periods

Employees are paid on a bi-weekly basis, every other Friday, by direct deposit. Pay stubs are available through the employee self-service portal.

6.2 Overtime

Non-exempt employees are paid 1.5 times their regular hourly rate for hours worked beyond 40 in a single workweek, in accordance with the Fair Labor Standards Act (FLSA) and applicable state law. Overtime must be approved by a manager in advance whenever possible.

6.3 Timekeeping

Non-exempt employees must accurately record all hours worked in the company's timekeeping system. Falsifying time records, or altering another employee's time record, is grounds for disciplinary action up to and including termination.

6.4 Performance Reviews & Merit Increases

Formal performance reviews are conducted annually each March, with an optional mid-year check-in in September. Merit increases and bonus eligibility are determined based on individual performance, business results, and market conditions.

6.5 Expense Reimbursement

Reasonable, pre-approved business expenses are reimbursed within 15 business days of submission through the expense management system, provided original receipts are attached for expenses over \$25.

7. Employee Benefits

The company offers a comprehensive benefits package to eligible employees. Full details, including plan documents and enrollment procedures, are available through the HR portal. Benefits eligibility for part-time, temporary, and intern classifications may vary.

7.1 Benefits Summary

Benefit	Eligibility	Company Contribution	Details
Medical Insurance	Full-time, after 30 days	75% of premium	PPO and HDHP options available
Dental & Vision	Full-time, after 30 days	60% of premium	Optional buy-up plans available
401(k) Retirement Plan	Full-time & part-time, after 90 days	100% match up to 4%	Immediate vesting

Benefit	Eligibility	Company Contribution	Details
Life & AD&D; Insurance	Full-time, after 30 days	100% (basic coverage)	1x annual salary; supplemental optional
Short/Long-Term Disability	Full-time, after 90 days	100% (basic coverage)	Replaces a portion of income during leave
Employee Assistance Program	All employees	Fully covered	Confidential counseling & referral services
Tuition Reimbursement	Full-time, after 1 year	Up to \$5,250/year	Requires pre-approval and passing grade
Commuter Benefits	All employees	Pre-tax deduction	Transit and parking accounts available

Note: Benefit plan terms, carriers, and contribution levels are reviewed annually and may change. The official plan documents and Summary Plan Descriptions govern in the event of any discrepancy with this handbook.

8. Leave & Time Off

8.1 Paid Time Off (PTO)

Full-time employees accrue PTO based on years of service, usable for vacation, personal time, or illness. PTO accrues each pay period and unused balances up to 40 hours may roll over into the next calendar year.

Years of Service	Annual PTO Accrual	Maximum Rollover	Accrual per Pay Period
0–2 years	15 days (120 hours)	40 hours	4.62 hours
3–5 years	20 days (160 hours)	40 hours	6.15 hours
6–10 years	23 days (184 hours)	40 hours	7.08 hours
11+ years	25 days (200 hours)	40 hours	7.69 hours

8.2 Company Holidays

The company observes the following paid holidays each year. If a holiday falls on a weekend, it is typically observed on the nearest weekday, as communicated by HR.

Holiday	Typical Date
New Year's Day	January 1
Memorial Day	Last Monday in May
Juneteenth	June 19
Independence Day	July 4
Labor Day	First Monday in September
Thanksgiving Day & Day After	Fourth Thursday & Friday in November
Winter Break	December 24 – January 1

8.3 Sick Leave

In jurisdictions where PTO does not satisfy statutory sick leave requirements, employees accrue sick leave separately in accordance with applicable state or local law. Contact HR for jurisdiction-specific details.

8.4 Parental & Family Leave

Eligible employees may take up to 12 weeks of job-protected leave under the Family and Medical Leave Act (FMLA) for the birth or adoption of a child, or to care for a family member with a serious health condition. The company additionally provides 6 weeks of paid parental leave for eligible full-time employees, which may run

concurrently with FMLA.

8.5 Bereavement Leave

Employees may take up to 5 paid days for the death of an immediate family member and up to 2 paid days for the death of an extended family member, subject to manager notification.

8.6 Jury Duty & Voting Leave

The company provides paid leave for jury duty and, where required by law, paid time off to vote. Employees should provide advance notice and documentation where available.

9. Health, Safety & Security

9.1 General Safety

The company is committed to providing a safe working environment in compliance with applicable OSHA regulations. Employees must report unsafe conditions, equipment, or practices to their manager or Facilities immediately.

9.2 Workplace Injuries

Any workplace injury or illness, no matter how minor, must be reported to a manager and HR within 24 hours. The company will provide information about workers' compensation benefits and coordinate any necessary medical care.

9.3 Emergency Procedures

Evacuation routes and emergency assembly points are posted throughout each office. Employees should familiarize themselves with these procedures and follow the direction of designated floor wardens during any emergency or drill.

9.4 Building Access

Office access outside of standard business hours requires a badge with after-hours access permissions. Employees should not allow unauthorized individuals to enter secured areas.

10. Technology & Social Media Use

10.1 Acceptable Use of Company Systems

Company computers, networks, and email are provided for business purposes. Incidental personal use is permitted provided it does not interfere with job performance, violate any policy, or involve illegal or offensive content. The company reserves the right to monitor and access company systems and communications, subject to applicable law.

10.2 Data Security

Employees must use strong, unique passwords, enable multi-factor authentication where available, and never share login credentials. Confidential or client data may not be stored on personal devices or unauthorized cloud services. Suspected security incidents must be reported to IT immediately.

10.3 Social Media

Employees are free to engage on personal social media, but should not disclose confidential company or client information, speak on behalf of the company without authorization, or post content that could reasonably be viewed as harassing, discriminatory, or defamatory. Employees should include a disclaimer that views expressed are their own when discussing industry topics.

10.4 Bring Your Own Device (BYOD)

Employees who access company email or systems on personal devices must enroll the device in the company's mobile device management (MDM) solution and agree to the associated security controls.

11. Performance Management & Discipline

The company uses a progressive discipline approach in most circumstances, intended to help employees understand and correct performance or conduct issues. However, the company reserves the right to skip any step, including proceeding directly to termination, depending on the severity of the issue.

11.1 Progressive Discipline Steps

Step	Action	Typical Use
1	Verbal Coaching	Minor, first-time performance or conduct issue
2	Written Warning	Repeated or moderate issue after coaching
3	Final Written Warning / Performance Improvement Plan	Continued issue; includes specific improvement goals and timeline
4	Termination of Employment	Failure to improve, or serious misconduct

11.2 Grounds for Immediate Termination

- Theft, fraud, or dishonesty
- Workplace violence or credible threats of violence
- Possession or use of illegal drugs or being impaired at work
- Harassment or discrimination in violation of company policy
- Serious breach of confidentiality or data security
- Falsification of company records, including timesheets

11.3 Performance Reviews

Managers are expected to provide ongoing feedback throughout the year in addition to the formal annual review cycle described in Section 6.4. Employees may request a meeting with HR if they disagree with a performance rating.

11.4 Grievance Procedure

Employees who have a workplace concern are encouraged to first discuss it with their manager. If unresolved, the employee may escalate the concern to HR in writing, and HR will investigate and respond within 10 business days.

12. Separation of Employment

12.1 Voluntary Resignation

Employees who choose to resign are asked to provide at least two weeks' written notice to allow for an orderly transition. Exempt employees are encouraged to provide additional notice where possible.

12.2 Involuntary Termination

As an at-will employer, the company may terminate employment at any time, with or without cause, subject to applicable law. Employees will be notified of the reason for termination where required by law or company practice.

12.3 Final Pay

Final wages, including any accrued and unused PTO, will be paid in accordance with applicable state law and no later than the next regularly scheduled payday, unless a shorter timeline is required.

12.4 Exit Process

Departing employees must return all company property, including laptops, badges, and access credentials, and complete an exit interview with HR. Continuation of health coverage under COBRA will be offered where applicable.

12.5 References

All requests for employment references or verification must be directed to HR. Managers should not provide informal references on behalf of the company.

13. Acknowledgement of Receipt

I acknowledge that I have received a copy of the Northfield & Cole Consulting Group Employee Handbook (the "Handbook"). I understand that I am responsible for reading and complying with the policies described in it. I understand that the Handbook is not a contract of employment and does not guarantee employment for any specific duration. I understand that my employment is at-will and that either I or the company may terminate the employment relationship at any time, with or without cause or notice, except as otherwise required by law.

I understand that the company may modify, amend, or discontinue any policy in this Handbook at any time, with or without notice, and that I will be informed of material changes.

Employee Name (Print):

Employee Signature:

Date:

Department:

Manager Name:

Please sign and return this page to Human Resources within five business days of receipt.